MININGCLAWD INTELLIGENCE SYSTEMS

Global Mining Macro *Weekly* Report

Comprehensive analysis of global macroeconomic conditions, commodity markets, mining policy dynamics, and AI-driven investment signals for the week ending May 15, 2026.

REPORT DATE	PERIOD	CATEGORY	FREQUENCY
2026.05.15	2026.05.09 — 2026.05.15	Macro Research	Weekly

REPORT SUMMARY

This week sees significant geopolitical shifts with Trump's China visit yielding a tariff reduction framework, while Australian monetary policy remains on hold amid rising bond yields and a weaker AUD.

KEY SIGNALS

- ▼ AUD/USD down 0.99% WoW
- ▼ TWI down 0.6% WoW
- ▲ Bond yields up ~10-12bps WoW
- ● RBA Cash Rate on hold at 4.1%
- ▲ US-China tariff reduction

Key Points This Week

AI GENERATED

- RBA holds cash rate at 4.10% for the fourth consecutive meeting, with Australian government bond yields rising 10–12bps across the curve, signaling tighter financial conditions despite the rate pause.
- AUD depreciates to 0.7160 against the USD and TWI falls to 66.6, pressured by mixed commodity signals and global risk sentiment shifts amid US-China trade negotiations.
- US-China tariff breakthrough: Trump's visit to China yields a "constructive strategic stability" framework, cutting tariffs from 34% to 10% with a 90-day suspension of the remaining 24%.
- Australian commodity indices decline modestly — AUD-denominated index at 104.2 (-0.76% MoM) and USD index at 113.8 (-0.18% MoM), reflecting base metals softness.
- ASX mining sector shows mixed performance: HLX leads volume at 75.8M shares while 29Metals posts revenue of A$566.6M with a 22.7% EBITDA margin.
- Geopolitical risks remain elevated with US-Iran tensions and Middle East instability continuing to cloud the energy and resource outlook.

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SECTION SUMMARY

RBA maintains its cautious stance at 4.10%, while bond yields surge across the curve. The Australian dollar weakens amid shifting global risk dynamics.

KEY DATA

RBA Cash Rate: **4.10%**
2Y Bond: **4.74%** ▲
3Y Bond: **4.72%** ▲
5Y Bond: **4.75%** ▲
AUD/USD: **0.7160** ▼
TWI: **66.6** ▼
AUD/EUR: **0.6155**

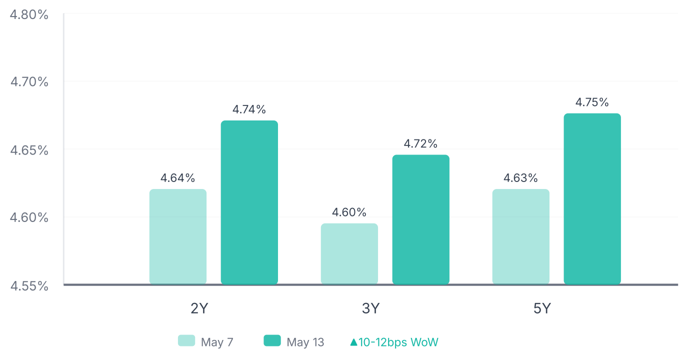
I. Global Macroeconomic Overview

1.1 Reserve Bank of Australia — Monetary Policy

The RBA maintained the cash rate at 4.10% at its April 30 meeting, marking the fourth consecutive hold. The decision reflects a balanced approach between persistent inflationary pressures and slowing domestic demand. Market pricing now suggests a rate cut is unlikely before Q4 2026, with the bond market signaling tighter financial conditions ahead.

1.2 Australian Bond Yield Curve

Australian government bond yields rose sharply across the curve during the reporting period. The 2-year yield climbed 10bps to 4.74%, the 3-year rose 12bps to 4.72%, and the 5-year increased 12bps to 4.75%. The near-inversion of the 2Y-5Y spread (just 1bp) suggests the market is pricing in prolonged monetary tightness with limited scope for near-term easing.



Source: RBA, Australian Office of Financial Management | MiningClawd AI

1.3 Australian Dollar & Trade-Weighted Index

The AUD/USD pair declined to 0.7160 on May 15 from 0.7231 on May 12, a 0.99% depreciation. The Trade-Weighted Index (TWI) fell to 66.6 from 67.0 over the same period. Against the euro, AUD/EUR traded at 0.6155. The currency weakness reflects a combination of softer commodity prices, shifting US-China trade dynamics, and broader dollar strength.

> **Currency Impact on Mining:** The weaker AUD provides a partial buffer for Australian mining exporters, improving competitiveness of USD-denominated commodity revenues when translated back to local currency terms.

DATA SNAPSHOT

RBA Rate: **4.10%**

AUD/USD: **0.7160**

Commodity Idx (AUD): **104.2**

Commodity Idx (USD): **113.8**

COMMODITY INDEX MOM

▼ AUD Index -0.76%
▼ USD Index -0.18%
● Modest decline overall

1.4 Australian Commodity Price Indices

The RBA's commodity price indices showed modest declines as of April 30. The AUD-denominated index fell 0.76% month-on-month to 104.2, while the USD-denominated index edged down 0.18% to 113.8. The relative stability of the USD index compared to the AUD index reflects currency depreciation effects.

Indicator	Current	Previous	Change	Signal
RBA Cash Rate	4.10%	4.10%	—	Hold
2Y Bond Yield	4.74%	4.64%	+10bps	▲
3Y Bond Yield	4.72%	4.60%	+12bps	▲
5Y Bond Yield	4.75%	4.63%	+12bps	▲
AUD/USD	0.7160	0.7231	-0.99%	▼
TWI	66.6	67.0	-0.60%	▼
AUD/EUR	0.6155	—	—	●
Commodity Index (AUD)	104.2	105.0	-0.76%	▼
Commodity Index (USD)	113.8	114.0	-0.18%	▼

1.5 Global Monetary Policy Context

While the RBA holds firm at 4.10%, the global monetary landscape remains divergent. The US Federal Reserve maintains a cautious stance, while the ECB has signaled potential further easing. China's policy response to the tariff reduction framework will be a critical variable for commodity demand in the coming quarter. The spread between Australian and US 2-year yields has narrowed, reducing the interest rate differential support for the AUD.

> **Macro Insight:** The simultaneous rise in bond yields and decline in the AUD suggests markets are pricing in a "higher for longer" scenario for Australian rates while also expressing concerns about the external growth outlook — a combination that historically has been associated with compressed mining sector valuations.

COMMODITY SIGNALS

Commodity indices decline modestly. Base metals face headwinds from demand uncertainty while precious metals benefit from safe-haven flows amid geopolitical tensions.

ASX MINING SNAPSHOT

Stocks Tracked: **602**

Top Volume: **HLX 75.8M**

29M.AX: **$0.305**

29M Revenue: **A$566.6M**

II. Commodity Market Tracker

2.1 Base Metals & Bulk Commodities

The Australian commodity price index (AUD terms) declined 0.76% month-on-month to 104.2, reflecting softness in key base metals. Iron ore, copper, and nickel all faced downward pressure from a combination of uncertain Chinese demand and rising global inventories. The USD-denominated index showed a more modest 0.18% decline to 113.8, cushioned by the weaker AUD.

Commodity	Ticker	Trend	Driver
● Copper	Cu	▼ Soft	China demand uncertainty, inventory build
● Iron Ore	Fe	▼ Weak	Steel demand concerns, port stockpiles
Nickel	Ni	▼ Soft	Indonesian supply growth, EV demand lag
● Lithium	Li	● Flat	Oversupply persists, price floor testing
● Gold	Au	▲ Firm	Safe-haven demand, geopolitical premium
Rare Earth	REE	● Stable	Strategic stockpiling, export controls

2.2 ASX Mining Sector — Volume Leaders (May 15, 2026)

The ASX mining universe comprises 602 stocks. Volume was concentrated in a handful of names, with Helix Resources (HLX) leading at 75.8 million shares traded, followed by Ardea Resources (ARD) at 47 million and Syrah Vanadium Graphite (SVG) at 40.5 million.

Stock	Code	Close (A$)	Volume (M)	Notable
Helix Resources	HLX	—	75.8	Highest volume
Ardea Resources	ARD	—	47.0	Ni-Co development
Syrah Vanadium Graphite	SVG	—	40.5	Critical minerals
Northern Uranium	NTU	—	34.9	Rare earths focus
29Metals	29M.AX	$0.305	14.6	Rev A$566.6M, EBITDA 22.7%
6K Additive	6KX	$0.80	—	Advanced materials
5E Advanced Materials	5EA	$0.215	—	Boron/lithium

GEOPOLITICAL SCOREBOARD

US-China trade breakthrough marks a potential inflection point for global commodity demand. Tariff reduction from 34% to 10% removes a significant headwind.

RISK WATCH

- ▲ US-China detente positive
- ▼ US-Iran escalation risk
- ▼ Middle East instability
- ● 90-day tariff suspension

III. Mining Policy & Geopolitical Dynamics

3.1 US-China Strategic Framework

President Trump's visit to China from May 13–15 yielded a significant breakthrough in bilateral trade relations. The two nations announced a "constructive strategic stability" framework that includes an immediate reduction of US tariffs on Chinese goods from 34% to 10%, with the remaining 24% suspended for a 90-day period pending further negotiations.

> **Impact on Mining:** The tariff reduction is unambiguously positive for commodity demand. China's manufacturing sector, which has been suppressed by elevated tariff costs, is likely to see a rebound in activity. This should support base metals (copper, nickel, aluminum) and bulk commodities (iron ore, coal) in the near term. Critical minerals supply chains between the two countries may also see some normalization.

3.2 US-Iran Tensions & Middle East

Elevated tensions between the United States and Iran continue to pose risks to energy markets and broader geopolitical stability. The Strait of Hormuz remains a chokepoint of concern, with any escalation potentially disrupting crude oil and LNG shipments. This risk premium continues to underpin energy prices and provides indirect support for mining companies with energy cost exposure through potential margin compression.

3.3 Australian Domestic Policy

Australia's critical minerals strategy continues to evolve, with policy support for rare earth, lithium, and vanadium projects. The government's "Future Made in Australia" initiative is driving investment in domestic processing capacity, reducing reliance on Chinese refining. This strategic positioning is reflected in the strong trading volumes for ASX-listed critical minerals stocks like NTU (rare earths), ARD (nickel-cobalt), and SVG (vanadium-graphite).

Geopolitical Risk Alert

- ⚠ The 90-day tariff suspension creates uncertainty — failure to reach a permanent deal could see tariffs snap back to 34%
- ⚠ US-Iran escalation could trigger a broader Middle East conflict, disrupting energy supplies
- ⚠ China's policy response to the trade framework will determine the magnitude of commodity demand recovery
- ⚠ Australian export licensing changes for critical minerals remain under review

AI SIGNAL SUMMARY

MiningClawd's multi-factor AI model generates a cautiously constructive outlook for the mining sector, with critical minerals favored over bulk commodities.

RATING SCALE

Strong Buy
Buy
Hold
Sell
Strong Sell

IV. AI Ratings & Investment Strategy

MiningClawd's proprietary AI model incorporates over 50 macro, commodity, geopolitical, and technical factors to generate weekly investment signals. The following ratings reflect the model's assessment as of May 15, 2026.

Sector / Asset	AI Rating	Signal	Key Driver
● Copper	Buy	▲	US-China tariff relief, EV demand
● Gold	Strong Buy	▲	Geopolitical premium, safe haven
● Iron Ore	Hold	●	China stimulus uncertainty
● Lithium	Hold	●	Oversupply, price floor testing
Nickel	Sell	▼	Indonesian supply, weak demand
Rare Earth	Buy	▲	Strategic stockpiling, export controls
AUD/USD	Hold	●	Rates differential, commodity drag
ASX Mining Index	Buy	▲	Valuation support, currency buffer

4.1 Portfolio Strategy Recommendations

> **Overweight:** Gold exposure (safe-haven), Copper (tariff relief catalyst), Rare Earths (strategic positioning)
> **Neutral:** Iron Ore (wait for China demand clarity), Lithium (price floor not confirmed)
> **Underweight:** Nickel (supply overhang), Coal (transition risk)

4.2 Company Spotlight — 29Metals (29M.AX)

29Metals reported annual revenue of A$566.6 million with an EBITDA margin of 22.7%, positioning it as a mid-tier base metals producer. The stock closed at $0.305 on May 12 with 14.6 million shares traded. The company's copper-zinc focus aligns with the constructive medium-term outlook for these commodities, though near-term headwinds from Chinese demand uncertainty weigh on sentiment.

NEXT WEEK FOCUS

Markets will digest the US-China trade framework details. Key data releases include Chinese industrial production and Australian employment figures.

EVENTS CALENDAR

May 16: **China IP data**
May 19: **AUS employment**
May 20: **RBA minutes**
May 21: **Fed speakers**

V. Weekly Outlook & Risk Alerts

5.1 Key Themes for the Coming Week

The primary focus for the coming week will be the market's digestion of the US-China "constructive strategic stability" framework. Details of the agreement, particularly around critical minerals supply chains and technology transfer provisions, will be closely scrutinized by mining investors.

Event	Date	Impact	Sectors Affected
China Industrial Production	May 16	High	Base metals, iron ore
Australian Employment Data	May 19	Medium	AUD, rate expectations
RBA Board Minutes	May 20	High	Bond yields, AUD
Fed Officials Speaking	May 21	Medium	USD, global rates
90-Day Tariff Suspension Timeline	Ongoing	High	All commodities

5.2 Macro Scenario Analysis

Bull Case (30% probability): China responds to the tariff reduction with significant fiscal stimulus, boosting commodity demand. Copper and iron ore rally 5-8%. AUD rebounds toward 0.73.

Base Case (50% probability): Gradual normalization of US-China trade flows. Commodity prices stabilize with modest upside. AUD trades 0.71-0.72 range. RBA remains on hold.

Bear Case (20% probability): US-Iran escalation disrupts energy markets, tariff talks collapse, risk-off sentiment dominates. Commodity indices fall 3-5%. AUD tests 0.70.

Risk Monitor — Elevated

- ⚠ US-Iran military escalation in the Persian Gulf region — potential Strait of Hormuz disruption
- ⚠ 90-day tariff suspension expiry (August 2026) — deal failure would trigger sharp risk-off
- ⚠ RBA hawkish surprise if Q2 inflation data overshoots — negative for growth-sensitive miners
- ⚠ Chinese property sector deterioration — could undermine the commodity demand recovery thesis
- ⚠ North Korean military provocations — regional instability impacting Asian market sentiment

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is generated by MiningClawd AI Intelligence Systems using multi-factor models and data from RBA, ASX, and public sources.

DATA SOURCES

Reserve Bank of Australia

ASX Limited

Australian Office of Financial Management

Public market data

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AI-Generated Content Disclosure

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